

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

A Novelization

Chapter 1: The Frozen Earth

The wind didn't howl; it accused. It pressed against the landscape of the Midwest, a flat, grey expanse of harvested fields and frozen mud, seeking a weakness, a crack in the world to whistle through.

The Medical Examiner pulled his coat tighter. He was a man of science, of cold tables and fluorescent lights, but out here, standing on the porch of the Rose farmhouse, science felt thin. The air smelled of ozone and snow, and something else—something faint and sweet, like flowers left too long on a grave.

He knocked. The sound was swallowed by the silence.

He stepped off the porch, his boots crunching on the frost-hardened ground. He looked up at the barn. A weather vane creaked, spinning lazily despite the biting gust. Inside, horses stamped, a nervous, rhythmic thudding against the wood.

Cats were everywhere. Feral, slinking shapes that poured around the foundation of the house like liquid shadow. They watched him with eyes that reflected no light.

And then he saw it.

Under the eaves of the porch, a grey, papery bulb pulsed. A hornets' nest. In the dead of winter. The insects swarmed around it, sluggish but alive, defying the frost that should have killed them months ago. They moved with a feverish, unnatural energy, a biological impossibility that made the hair on the M.E.'s arms stand up.

Something is wrong here, the house seemed to whisper. *The laws of physics are just suggestions.*

The back door opened. Maria Rose stepped out. She looked like a woman who had been hollowed out by grief, her eyes rimmed with red, her hands shaking as she wiped them on her apron.

"You are the Medical Examiner?" she asked. Her voice was brittle.

"Yes, ma'am."

She nodded and held the door open. He stepped inside, leaving the cold and the impossible hornets behind.

The kitchen was warm, but it wasn't a comforting warmth. It was stifling. A young man sat at the table, his hands wrapped around a coffee mug as if it were the only anchor in a storm. Three teenage girls sat nearby, weeping softly, a huddled mass of flannel and tears.

Maria led him past them, into the hallway. A large wooden crucifix hung on the wall, dominating the space. The M.E. glanced at it. The Christ figure looked pained, as always, but here, in this house, the agony seemed... active.

In the living room, a man sat in an easy chair. Samuel Rose. He was staring at a blank television screen, his face a mask of shock. In his hands, he clutched a dirty, one-eyed baby doll, his knuckles white.

"Mr. Rose?" the M.E. said softly.

Samuel didn't blink. He just stared into the grey static of the unlit screen.

Maria touched the M.E.'s arm. "Upstairs."

They climbed the stairs. The wood groaned under their feet. At the top of the landing, a door opened.

Father Richard Moore stepped out.

He wasn't what the M.E. expected. He wasn't a soft, suburban priest with soft hands and platitudes. He was gaunt, intense, with eyes that looked like they had looked into a furnace and refused to blink. He wore his collar like armor.

They locked eyes. The priest didn't speak. He just stepped aside.

The M.E. entered the bedroom.

Later, in the kitchen. The silence was heavier now.

"I'm sorry, Mr. Rose," the M.E. said, struggling to keep his voice professional. "But I cannot state conclusively that the cause of death is natural. Your daughter... she..."

He trailed off. He couldn't say it. He couldn't describe the twisted state of the body, the malnutrition, the sheer physical ruin of the girl upstairs.

Father Moore turned to the window. He looked out at the backyard, past the frost, past the barn.

Standing in the shadow of the trees was a figure. Tall. Draped in a long black robe. A broad-brimmed black hat obscured the face.

The figure stood perfectly still, the robes flaring in the wind. Watching. Waiting.

"Excuse me... Father?" a policeman said.

Moore blinked. He looked back at the yard. The figure stepped into the shadow of the barn and dissolved. Gone. Like smoke.

"Father Moore," the policeman said, his hand resting on his belt. "You'll have to come with us."

Chapter 2: The Shark in the Sidebar

The bar was called "Sidebar," because lawyers love a pun almost as much as they love the sound of their own voices. It was dark, expensive, and smelled of gin and ambition.

Erin Bruner sat at the end of the bar, a stack of legal pleadings next to her martini. She was striking, sharp-edged, wearing a suit that cost more than the Rose family's tractor. She marked the papers with a Montblanc pen, slashing through weak arguments like a butcher trimming fat.

"There's ambition," a voice drawled.

Karl Gunderson. Senior Partner. He stood with a circle of cronies, men with silver hair and gold watches.

"Gentlemen, you know Erin Bruner," Karl said.

"The Van Hopper case," one of the cronies said, nodding. "You got a murderer off, didn't you?"

"The system worked," Erin said, not looking up.

"Or you worked the system," the man replied. "It's not like the jury said he was innocent."

Erin capped her pen. She turned, giving him a smile that didn't reach her eyes. "But then, who is?"

The men chuckled. Cynicism was the currency here, and Erin was rich.

Karl pulled her aside. "Have you seen the news? The priest? Negligent homicide."

"I heard," Erin said. "Exorcism gone wrong. Sounds messy. I don't do messy."

"The Archdiocese asked for you," Karl said. "Specifically."

"Why me?"

"Because you're smart. And you're convincing. They want you to get him to take a plea deal. Avoid a trial. Avoid the embarrassment."

Erin took a sip of her martini. "And if I do?"

"Then the rising star keeps rising."

"I want Senior Partner, Karl. My name on the door. Right next to yours."

Karl laughed, a low, wet sound. "You can't win if you don't play."

"And don't play if you can't win," Erin countered.

"Do this for me," Karl said, leaning in close, smelling of scotch and entitlement. "Get the deal. And if he won't take it... keep him off the stand. The Church doesn't want him ranting about demons on the 6 o'clock news."

"Done," Erin said. "His tab." She gestured to the bartender and walked out, leaving Karl holding the bill.

The County Jail was a cathedral of concrete and misery.

Erin sat on a metal folding chair in Father Moore's cell. The air smelled of industrial cleaner and unwashed bodies.

"I'm not Catholic," she said, crossing her legs. "I'm agnostic, I guess. I'm not sure."

Father Moore sat on his bunk. He looked calm, impossibly calm for a man facing ten years in prison. "If you're not sure, then you are one."

"Look, Father," Erin said, shifting gears. "I'm here to save your life. Or at least your freedom. The D.A. is offering reckless endangerment. Time served. You walk out today."

"I won't accept a plea," Moore said.

"Why? Pride?"

"Truth," Moore said. "I want Emily's story to be told."

"Her story? That you killed her?"

"That she died for a reason," Moore said. His intensity was magnetic. It pulled at Erin, despite her armor. "If I let you represent me, will you let me testify? Will you let me tell the world what really happened?"

Erin calculated. A trial. A high-profile, media-circus trial. It was risky. It was dangerous.

It was exactly what she needed to make Partner.

"Fine," she said. "I'll let you tell her story. But only if you let me do whatever I have to do to win."

Moore nodded. "Deal."

Chapter 3: The Smell of Burning

The past is a ghost that haunts the present.

Six months ago, Emily Rose was just a girl with a letter in her hand.

"It's a scholarship, Mama!" she screamed, jumping on her bed. Her sisters crowded around her, a tangle of limbs and laughter. "They want me! The University wants me!"

Maria Rose stood in the doorway, holding the envelope. She didn't smile. She saw the distance in the postmark. The city. The world.

"You will be leaving us," Maria whispered.

"I'll be okay, Mama," Emily said, hugging her. "I promise."

But promises are fragile things.

The University was a landscape of stone towers and falling leaves. Emily walked through the quad, her breath puffing in the chill air. She was happy. She had met a boy, Jason. She was studying philosophy. She was alive.

Then, the smell hit her.

It wasn't leaves. It wasn't autumn.

It was meat. Burning meat. And sulfur.

She stopped. The world seemed to tilt. The students walking past her blurred. The shadows stretched, detaching themselves from the trees, reaching out like fingers.

"Emily?"

She turned. No one was there.

That night, alone in her dorm room, she woke up at 3:00 AM.

The room was silent. Too silent.

She smelled it again. Burning.

She got up, checking the hall. Nothing. Just the long, empty corridor of the dorm.

She went back to bed. She pulled the covers up.

Click.

She froze.

On her desk, a cup of pens rattled. It slid across the wood, driven by an invisible finger. It tipped over. *Clatter.*

Emily sat up, her heart hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird.

Then, the weight fell.

It hit the mattress with a *thump*, pressing down beside her. The bed springs groaned.

Something invisible and heavy was on top of her.

It pushed her down. It clamped her arms to her sides. It was heavy, dense, and hot.

She tried to scream, but a hand—a heavy, unseen hand—clamped over her mouth.

She felt it moving. Writhing against her. It wasn't just holding her down; it was exploring her. Violating her. It moved under her nightshirt, cold fingers tracing her ribs, her stomach.

She thrashed, her eyes wide, staring at the empty air that was crushing the life out of her.

"Mine," a voice whispered. Not in her ear. In her head.

Then, as suddenly as it came, it lifted.

Emily gasped, sucking in air, and scrambled backward, falling off the bed, crawling into the corner, shaking, weeping, while the smell of burning hair filled the room.

Present Day.

Erin walked across the campus with Jason, Emily's boyfriend. He looked young, broken.

"She said it started at the hospital," Jason said, kicking at a pile of wet leaves. "After the dorm thing. She said... she said the faces changed."

"Changed how?" Erin asked.

"She saw demons," Jason whispered. "Everywhere. In the rain. In the windows. In the faces of people she loved."

He looked at Erin. "She wasn't crazy, Ms. Bruner. I know how that sounds. But she wasn't. She was... hunted."

Erin nodded, jotting a note. *Hunted.*

It was a good word. She just hoped the jury would buy it.

Chapter 4: The Witching Hour

The city slept, but Erin Bruner did not.

Her apartment was a glass box in the sky, a monument to billable hours and solitary success. She lay in bed, the silk sheets cool against her skin, staring at the ceiling. The streetlights from below cast long, shifting shadows across the room.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

The alarm clock on her nightstand was loud in the silence.

Erin rolled over. The red digits glowed: **2:59 AM**.

She watched the seconds count down. 58... 59...

3:00 AM.

Tick.

Then, silence.

The ticking stopped.

Erin frowned. She sat up, tapping the clock. The digits were frozen. The second hand on her expensive analog watch on the dresser—she could see it glinting in the moonlight—was motionless.

Then came the smell.

It was subtle at first, like a match struck in another room. But it grew stronger. Acrid. Oily. The smell of burning insulation, of singed hair.

Erin got out of bed. "Hello?" she called out. Her voice sounded small in the high-ceilinged room.

She walked into the living room. The shadows seemed to pool in the corners, darker than they should be. The air was heavy, charged with static.

She checked the kitchen. The stove was cold. The electronics were off.

Just a fuse, she told herself. *A power surge.*

She turned back to the bedroom.

SLAM.

The door to her bedroom—the heavy, solid wood door—swung shut with violent force. The sound was like a gunshot.

Erin jumped, her heart leaping into her throat. She stared at the closed door. She lived alone. The windows were closed. There was no draft.

She reached for the knob. Her hand trembled. The brass was ice cold.

She turned it and pushed. The room was empty. But the window—the window she had latched before bed—was wide open. The curtains billowed inward, looking like shrouds in the moonlight.

On the nightstand, beside the frozen clock, her gold locket was gone.

The next morning, the courtroom was a different kind of theater.

Ethan Thomas stood before the jury, looking like a choirboy who had grown up to be an executioner. He held a manila folder.

"Epilepsy," Thomas said, his voice warm and reasonable. "A medical condition. Treatable. Understandable."

He put a photo on the easel. It was Emily, smiling, healthy.

"This is Emily Rose before Father Moore."

He swapped the photo. The jury gasped.

The new image was a nightmare. Emily's face was gaunt, her eyes sunken into black pits, her lips cracked and bleeding. She looked like a famine victim.

"And this," Thomas said, his voice dropping to a whisper, "is Emily Rose after Father Moore told her to stop taking her medicine."

Dr. Briggs took the stand. He was arrogant, precise, the kind of doctor who looked at a patient and saw a broken machine.

"Epileptic Psychosis," Briggs declared. "A rare condition. The seizures trigger hallucinations. Paranoia. The patient believes they are possessed."

"And the cure?" Thomas asked.

"Gambutrol. Tegretol. Medical intervention."

"And if she had continued the treatment?"

"She would be alive today," Briggs said. "Without question."

Erin watched the jury. They were nodding. They liked science. Science was safe. Science didn't hide in the dark at 3:00 AM.

Chapter 5: The Spider and the Saint

Erin needed a counter-punch. She called Dr. Sadira Adani, an anthropologist who treated the supernatural with the same clinical detachment Briggs applied to biology.

"Possession is a universal human experience," Adani testified. "It is not psychosis. Psychotics are confused. Emily was lucid. She knew what was happening to her."

Ethan Thomas shredded her on cross-examination. He mocked her research, calling it "voodoo science" and "snake-handling." He made the jury laugh.

Erin felt the case slipping away. She needed something visceral. Something to shake them.

She put Samuel Rose, Emily's father, on the stand.

"Tell us about the night you called Father Moore," Erin said gently.

Samuel looked old, worn down like a stone in a river. "We heard her... eating."

"Eating?"

"In her bedroom. We went upstairs."

Flashback.

The farmhouse bedroom was dim. The walls were scratched, the wallpaper peeled away in long strips where Emily had clawed at the plaster.

Emily was crouched in the corner. She wasn't human anymore. She was a thing of angles and tension.

"Emily?" Alice, her sister, whispered.

Emily turned.

Her mouth was a ruin. Blood smeared her chin. But it was what she was holding that made Alice scream.

A handful of spiders. Daddy long-legs, wolf spiders, beetles. They wriggled in her grip.

Emily's eyes were black holes. She didn't blink. She raised her hand and shoved the insects into her mouth.

Crunch.

The sound was wet and brittle. She chewed, the legs twitching between her lips. She swallowed.

"They are hungry," she whispered. Her voice was a growl, deep and masculine. "We are hungry."

Then she screamed. It wasn't a scream of pain. It was a scream of pure, concentrated hate. She threw herself backward, her body arching into a crab-walk, scuttling across the floor with impossible speed.

Present Day.

The courtroom was silent. Samuel Rose was weeping.

"She ate them," he sobbed. "My little girl... she ate them."

Ethan Thomas didn't look smug anymore. The jury wasn't looking at him. They were looking at Samuel. And they were terrified.

Chapter 6: The Tape

"I have a witness," Ray, Erin's investigator, said. "He was there. At the exorcism."

Dr. Edmund Cartwright met Erin in a city park. It was dusk. The pigeons were fighting over scraps of bread.

Cartwright was a wreck. He wore a dirty coat, and his hands shook as he fed the birds. He kept looking over his shoulder, scanning the tree line.

"I'm a man of science," Cartwright said, his voice trembling. "I was. Until that night."

"Will you testify?" Erin asked.

"They'll kill me," Cartwright whispered.

"Who?"

"Them. The ones in the dark."

He reached into his pocket and pulled out a micro-cassette tape. "Moore recorded it. He wanted proof. Take it."

Erin took the tape. It felt heavy, heavier than plastic should be.

"I'll testify," Cartwright said, standing up. "But you need to listen. You need to know what you're dealing with."

That night, Erin sat in her living room. She put the tape in her recorder.

She pressed play.

Hiss. Crackle.

Then, the voice.

It wasn't human. It was a cacophony. A layered, distorted sound—like a choir screaming in a burning church.

"One... two... three... four... five... six..."

Erin felt the temperature in the room drop. Her breath misted in the air.

"We are the ones who dwell within..."

The voice on the tape laughed. It was a wet, gurgling sound.

Erin stared at the recorder. The tape spun.

Tick. Tick. Tick.

She looked at her watch.

It stopped.

3:00 AM.

The tape recorder clicked off on its own.

But the voice didn't stop.

"Erin..."

It came from the hallway.

Erin stood up. She walked to the door. She looked through the peephole.

The hallway was empty.

But she could smell it. The burning. The rot.

And she knew, with a certainty that defied all her logic, that she had opened a door that she couldn't close.

Chapter 7: The Unbinding

"This tape," Father Moore said from the witness stand, his voice steady, "is the recording of the exorcism performed on October 31st."

The courtroom was silent. Even the air seemed to hold its breath. Erin pressed play.

Static. The sound of rain.

"I, Father Richard Moore..."

The scene dissolved. The courtroom walls melted away, replaced by the peeling wallpaper of the farmhouse bedroom.

It was Halloween. The storm outside was a physical assault, rain lashing the glass like gravel. Inside, the air was thick, pressurized.

Emily lay on the bed. She was tied down with strips of heavy cloth. Her body was rigid, vibrating with a low-frequency hum that rattled the teeth of everyone in the room.

"We begin," Moore said.

He sprinkled the holy water.

Sizzle.

It sounded like meat hitting a hot grill. Emily screamed—a sound that started as a girl's cry and tore itself open into a predator's roar.

"IT BURNS!"

She thrashed, the bed frame groaning. Her wrists twisted in the restraints, the skin tearing, blood weeping into the cloth. She didn't care.

"Exorcizamus te!" Moore shouted, his voice fighting the thunder.

Emily's head snapped up. Her eyes were gone. No iris, no pupil. Just a flat, matte blackness that absorbed the dim light.

"Your Latin is sloppy, Priest," she sneered. The voice was urbane, mocking. "You missed a declension."

In the hallway, the crucifix on the wall rattled. *Bang. Bang.* Then, slowly, deliberately, the nail gave way. It swung upside down.

In the bedroom, the shadows moved. Not cast by any light, they detached from the corners, slinking across the floor.

"Who are you?" Moore demanded.

"I am the one who dwells within," the voice hissed.

Suddenly, Emily sat up. The cloth restraints didn't loosen; they *snapped*. Thick canvas tore like wet paper.

She grabbed the doll from the nightstand—the one-eyed baby doll—and hurled it. It smashed against the wall, the plastic head shattering.

Then, the cats came.

They poured through the open door, a wave of fur and claws. Barn cats. Feral. They didn't meow; they shrieked. They launched themselves at Moore, a whirlwind of teeth and claws, biting at his legs, his cassock.

Moore fell, shielding his face.

In the chaos, Emily moved. She didn't walk; she flowed. She launched herself at the window.

CRASH.

Glass exploded outward. She was gone, diving into the storm, into the night.

Chapter 8: The Barn

The barn was a cathedral of rot.

The rain hammered the tin roof, a deafening drumroll. Inside, the air smelled of wet hay, horse manure, and sulfur.

They cornered her near the water trough. Samuel, Jason, and Moore.

Emily was in the water. She was thrashing, the icy water boiling around her. Steam rose from her skin.

"Get her out!" Moore screamed.

They dragged her onto the straw. She was heavy, impossibly heavy, dense as lead.

"Hold her!"

And then, she howled.

It wasn't a human sound. It was a biologically impossible noise—the shriek of a primate, the roar of a lion, the screech of a raptor—all layered on top of each other. It vibrated in the marrow of their bones.

The horses in the stalls went mad. They kicked the wood, splintering the heavy oak, eyes rolling white in terror.

Dr. Cartwright, the psychiatrist, huddled in the corner, covering his ears, sobbing. His science had broken.

"Names!" Moore roared, kneeling over her, the Bible clutched like a weapon. "I command you! Tell me your names!"

Emily stopped struggling. She went perfectly still.

She opened her mouth.

The barn filled with insects.

Or maybe it didn't. Maybe it was just in their minds. But they saw them. Roaches pouring from the cracks in the beams. Spiders dropping on silk threads like paratroopers. Snakes coiling in the hay.

Moore brushed a centipede off his bible. He didn't stop.

"TELL ME!"

Emily's face contorted, muscles shifting under the skin like worms. She sat up, levitating inches off the straw.

"One," she whispered. The voice was ancient, dusty. "I am the one who dwelt within Cain!"

Thunder cracked. The barn shook.

"Two!" A hiss. "I am the one who dwelt within Nero!"

"Three!" A growl. "I once dwelt within Judas!"

"Four!" A giggle, high and manic. "I was with Legion!"

"Five!" A voice of cold iron. "I am Belial!"

Moore was weeping now, the spiritual pressure crushing him. "And the sixth? Who are you?"

Emily smiled. It was a smile that promised the end of all things.

"And I..."

The shadows in the barn coalesced. A tall, black-robed figure stood behind her, faceless, towering.

"I am Lucifer," the voice boomed, doubling on itself, a chorus of one. "The Devil in the Flesh."

The horses broke free. They stampeded through the barn doors, galloping into the night.

Emily collapsed.

The insects vanished. The figure dissolved.

Silence rushed back in, louder than the storm.

Moore crawled over to her. She was breathing. But she was empty. The vessel was cracked.

"We failed," Moore whispered, looking at the devastation. "God help us, we failed."

Chapter 9: The Broken Witness

"Tibetan monks," Ethan Thomas said, leaning against the jury railing. "They can produce two distinct tones simultaneously. Did you know that, Father?"

Moore sat on the stand, exhausted. "No."

"So, the 'demonic voices' on your tape... could simply be a psychotic girl straining her vocal cords?"

"No," Moore said. "I know what I heard."

Erin watched the jury. They were wavering. The tape had terrified them, but Thomas was giving them a lifeboat: Logic. Science. Monks.

She needed Cartwright.

She found him in the parking lot behind the courthouse. It was dusk. The streetlights buzzed, flickering in the cold wind.

"Dr. Cartwright!" Erin called.

He spun around. He looked worse than he had in the park. His eyes were wide, the pupils dilated. He smelled of scotch and fear.

"I can't do it," he stammered. "I can't go back in there."

"You have to," Erin said, grabbing his arm. "You're the only one who can corroborate the tape."

Cartwright pulled away. He looked past her, at the tree line. "They're watching, Erin. Don't you see them?"

"Who?"

"The dark ones."

He stepped back. "Tell Moore I'm sorry. Tell him... I know."

He stepped into the road.

The truck came out of nowhere. No headlights. Just a roar of an engine and the squeal of tires.

CRUNCH.

It hit him with the force of a battering ram. Cartwright flew over the hood. He hit the windshield, glass spider-webbing around his impact, then rolled off onto the asphalt.

The truck skidded, then sped away.

Erin ran to him.

Cartwright lay twisted. His neck was broken, his head turned 180 degrees, staring back at his own spine. His eyes were open, fixed on the sky. Fixed on something Erin couldn't see.

The blood didn't pool; it spread, dark and thick, steaming in the cold air. The silence that followed was absolute.

Chapter 10: The Letter

"We've lost," Erin said. She sat in Moore's cell. She was shaking. "Cartwright is dead."

Moore nodded slowly. He didn't look surprised. "Then it falls to you, Erin."

"To me? I'm a lawyer, not a priest."

"Read this."

He handed her a yellow envelope.

That night, alone in her apartment—with all the lights on—Erin read Emily's letter.

Flashback. Predawn. The Wheat Field.

Emily walked out of the farmhouse. The fog was thick, a white ocean that swallowed the world.

She was dying. Her body was a wreck of bruises and broken bones. But as she walked, the pain faded.

She saw a light. Soft. Golden.

A woman stood in the mist. She wore simple robes. Her face was kind, but sad.

"Emily," the woman said. "Heaven is not blind to your pain."

"Why?" Emily wept. "Why won't they leave?"

"I can cut the cord," the Virgin Mary said. "You can come with me now. You can have peace."

Emily looked down. She saw her own body lying on the wet grass, writhing in agony. She saw the demons waiting.

"Or," the Virgin said, "you can stay. You can suffer. And through your suffering, the world will know that the spiritual realm is real."

Emily looked at the light. Then she looked at the dark.

"People say God is dead," Emily whispered. "But how can they think that if I show them the Devil?"

She closed her eyes. "I choose to stay."

The cord snapped back. Emily woke up in her body. The pain returned, a thousand times worse. She screamed.

And then, blood began to weep from her hands. From her feet. The Stigmata. The mark of the saint.

Chapter 11: Fear and Trembling

Erin stood at the podium. She didn't have notes. She didn't have science. She had doubt.

"I am a woman of doubt," she told the jury. "Ethan Thomas is a man of faith. But here, in this room, we deal with possibilities."

She walked the line.

"Is it possible she was epileptic? Yes. Is it possible she was possessed? I don't know. But Emily believed it. Father Moore believed it. And they acted on that belief."

She looked at Moore.

"Don't send a good man to prison for loving a girl enough to fight the Devil for her soul."

The jury was out for four days.

When they returned, the Foreman wouldn't look at the prosecutor.

"We find the defendant... Guilty of Negligent Homicide."

Erin's heart stopped.

"However," the Foreman continued, "we recommend a sentence of... time served."

Judge Brewster banged the gavel. "Accepted. Father Moore, you are free to go."

It was a compromise. A legal paradox. Guilty, but innocent.

Epilogue. The Cemetery.

Spring had come. The snow was gone, replaced by green shoots pushing through the earth.

Erin and Moore stood by the grave.

"Do you believe her?" Erin asked. "About the vision?"

"I believe that faith and doubt can coexist," Moore said. "Faith without doubt can be a dangerous thing."

Erin touched the locket around her neck. "I got offered a job. Teaching."

"Will you take it?"

"Maybe. I think I'm done with corporate law."

She looked at the headstone.

****EMILY ROSE****

1986 - 2005

And below the date, the epitaph:

"Work out your own salvation with fear and trembling."

Erin walked away. The wind blew, warm and alive. She didn't look back at the shadows. She knew they were there. But she also knew, for the first time, that she wasn't walking alone.

THE END